

To: The INFORMS Prize Committee

Letter of Support for Prof. Mohammad Dehghani, IE 5374: Applied Generative AI

Dear Members of the INFORMS Prize Committee,

I am writing in support of Prof. Mohammad Dehghani's nomination for the Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice. I served as the inaugural Teaching Assistant for IE 5374: Applied Generative AI across two consecutive semesters, Fall 2025 and Spring 2025. In that role, I worked closely with the professor, assisted in shaping the curriculum, facilitated all lab sessions, mentored students through their final projects, and coordinated the course's guest speaker program.

The course is built around a four-phase framework called Discover, Design, Deploy, Demonstrate, which mirrors the lifecycle of a real production AI system. Students begin with the technical foundations of large language models and move progressively into building functional systems. By the end of the course, they have designed and implemented agent workflows and deployed prototypes that they present through live demos. This commitment to genuine deployment over slide-based project reports is core to what makes the course effective.

Over the past few semesters, this course has delivered significant value and impact. A significant number of students directly credited IE 5374 with helping them secure AI-focused co-op placements and full-time job offers. I received messages from students describing interviews in which their course projects served as their portfolio work, and in which the technical depth they had developed allowed them to perform well in conversations that most graduates are not prepared for. Prof. Dehghani went above and beyond just introducing students to AI by giving them the skills to successfully enter the job market as AI engineers.

One dimension of the course I want to highlight is the emphasis Prof. Dehghani placed on keeping students updated in real time. With his support, I created and ran a recurring segment called The Buzz, a weekly briefing on current developments in AI that I presented at the start of each class. This was not a required course component, it emerged from the culture Prof. Dehghani established, one in which students needed to engage with the industry as it was evolving, not static. Students consistently cited this as one of the most useful parts of their experience.

By the measure of producing effective practitioners, IE 5374 under Prof. Dehghani's direction is an outstanding example. The student outcomes are documented, the curriculum is comprehensive, and the course has already demonstrated that it prepares graduates to contribute from their first day on the job. I offer my support for this nomination without reservation.

Respectfully,



Shayan Menahi

Commencement Speaker 2026, Northeastern University
Product Manager – AI Experiences

T Mobile